

Word family: **balance / balances / balanced / balancing / imbalance / unbalanced**

Base word: balance

Part of speech: **noun** and **verb**

Related forms:

balance (n.) — 平衡；均衡；餘額；天平

balance (v.) — 使平衡；權衡；兼顧

balanced (adj.) — 平衡的；均衡的；客觀的

balancing (n./adj.) — 平衡；權衡中的

imbalance (n.) — 失衡；不均衡

unbalanced (adj.) — 不平衡的；失衡的

Useful expressions / extensions:

keep / lose your balance

a sense of balance

balance between A and B

strike / find a balance

work-life balance

balanced diet

balanced view

balance competing needs

balance the books

account balance

remaining balance

balance due

on balance

tip the balance

hang in the balance

imbalance

Meaning in this passage

> He was firm, but fair, and that **balance** is not easy to find.

Here, **balance** means:

a successful combination of two different qualities without either becoming too strong — 平衡；均衡

The speaker means Mr Chan combined:

* **firmness** — 有原則、堅定

* **fairness** — 公平、公道

in the right proportion.

中文翻譯：

他很有原則，但同時也很公平，而這種**平衡**其實並不容易找到。

So here:

balance = 兩種不同特質之間恰到好處的配合

1. **balance between A and B — A 與 B 之間的平衡**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> He was firm, but fair, and that **balance** is not easy to find.

他很有原則，但同時也很公平，而這種**平衡**並不容易找到。

Practice 2

> Good teaching requires a **balance between discipline and flexibility**.

好的教學需要在**紀律和彈性之間取得平衡**。

Practice 3

> She tries to maintain a **balance between work and family life**.

她努力在**工作和家庭生活之間保持平衡**。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance between A and B = 兩種不同需要、特質或力量之間保持適當比例，不讓任何一方過度

2. **find / strike a balance — 找到 / 取得平衡**

Practice 1

> Teachers need to **find a balance** between support and independence.

老師需要在支援和自主之間**找到平衡**。

Practice 2

> It's difficult to **strike the right balance**.

要**取得恰當平衡**並不容易。

MCQ-ready definition:

find/strike a balance = 在兩個或多個不同要求之間找到合適的中間點

3. **keep / maintain a balance** — 保持平衡

Practice 1

> We need to **maintain a balance** between speed and quality.

我們需要在速度和質素之間**保持平衡**。

Practice 2

> The policy tries to **keep a balance** between freedom and safety.

這項政策嘗試在自由和安全之間**保持平衡**。

MCQ-ready definition:

maintain/keep a balance = 令不同因素持續維持適當比例

4. **physical balance** — 身體平衡

A major literal sense.

Practice 1

> She lost her **balance** and fell.

她失去**平衡**，跌倒了。

Practice 2

> Standing on one leg tests your **balance**.

單腳站立可以測試你的**平衡力**。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance = 身體保持穩定、不跌倒的能力

5. **keep / lose your balance — 保持 / 失去平衡**

Practice 1

> He struggled to **keep his balance** on the wet floor.

他在濕滑地面上努力**保持平衡**。

Practice 2

> I **lost my balance** on the stairs.

我在樓梯上**失去平衡**。

MCQ-ready definition:

keep/lose your balance = 維持 / 失去身體穩定狀態

6. **sense of balance — 平衡感**

Practice 1

> Dancers need a strong **sense of balance**.

舞蹈員需要很好的**平衡感**。

Practice 2

> His **sense of balance** improved with practice.

他的**平衡感**隨練習而改善。

MCQ-ready definition:

sense of balance = 感知身體位置並維持穩定的能力

7. **balance something physically — 使某物保持平衡**

As a verb.

Practice 1

> She **balanced the book on her head**.

她把書**平衡地放在頭上**。

Practice 2

> He **balanced the tray carefully**.

他小心地**保持托盤平衡**。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance something = 令某物保持穩定，不向一邊跌下

8. **balance on something — 在某物上保持平衡**

Practice 1

> The child **balanced on one foot**.

孩子用一隻腳**保持平衡**。

Practice 2

> The bird **balanced on the branch**.

那隻鳥在樹枝上**保持平衡**。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance on X = 在 X 上維持身體穩定

9. **balance needs / priorities — 權衡不同需要 / 優先事項**

A major abstract verb sense.

Practice 1

> Managers must **balance different priorities**.

經理必須**權衡不同優先事項**。

Practice 2

> Parents often have to **balance work and childcare**.

父母經常要**兼顧工作和育兒**。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance A and B = 同時考慮並兼顧兩個不同的需要、目標或責任

10. **balance competing interests — 平衡互相衝突的利益**

Practice 1

> The policy tries to **balance competing interests**.

這項政策嘗試**平衡互相衝突的利益**。

Practice 2

> A leader must **balance the needs of different groups**.

領袖必須**兼顧不同群體的需要**。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance competing interests = 在彼此衝突的利益之間作合理權衡

11. **work-life balance — 工作與生活平衡**

Practice 1

> Good **work-life balance** is important.

良好的**工作與生活平衡**很重要。

Practice 2

> She changed jobs to improve her **work-life balance**.

她轉工是為了改善**工作與生活平衡**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****work-life balance = 工作責任與私人生活之間的適當分配****

12. ****balanced diet — 均衡飲食****

Practice 1

> Children need a ****balanced diet****.

孩子需要****均衡飲食****。

Practice 2

> A ****balanced diet**** includes a variety of foods.

****均衡飲食****包含多種不同食物。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****balanced diet = 含有不同種類營養、比例適當的飲食****

13. ****balanced view / argument — 平衡、客觀的看法 / 論述****

Practice 1

> The article gives a ****balanced view**** of the issue.

這篇文章對議題提供了****平衡客觀的觀點****。

Practice 2

> A good essay should present a ****balanced argument****.

好的文章應提出****平衡的論述****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****balanced view/argument = 公平考慮不同觀點，不偏向單一一方的看法或論述****

14. **balanced person / personality** — 情緒穩定、性格均衡的人

Practice 1

> She is calm and **well-balanced**.

她冷靜，而且**性格穩定**。

Practice 2

> He seems emotionally **balanced**.

他看起來情緒上很**穩定**。

MCQ-ready definition:

balanced person = 情緒、判斷或性格較穩定，不容易走向極端的人

15. **balance (餘額)** — 餘額；結餘

A completely different financial sense.

Practice 1

> What's the **balance** in your account?

你的戶口**餘額**是多少？

Practice 2

> The account has a low **balance**.

這個戶口的**結餘**很低。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance = 戶口中在收支後仍然剩下的金額

16. **account balance** — 戶口餘額

Practice 1

> You can check your **account balance** online.

你可以在網上查看**戶口餘額**。

Practice 2

> My **account balance** is lower than I expected.

我的**戶口結餘**比預期低。

MCQ-ready definition:

account balance = 某個銀行或金融戶口目前剩餘的金額

17. **remaining balance — 剩餘款項**

Practice 1

> Please pay the **remaining balance** by Friday.

請在星期五前支付**餘下款項**。

Practice 2

> The **balance** must be paid in full.

餘款必須全數支付。

MCQ-ready definition:

remaining balance = 已支付部分款項後仍未付清的金額

18. **balance due — 應付餘額**

Practice 1

> The **balance due** is \$200.

尚欠款項是 200 元。

Practice 2

> Please settle the **balance due** within 30 days.

請在 30 天內付清**應付餘額**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****balance due = 目前仍需要支付的剩餘金額****

19. ****balance the books — 使賬目收支平衡****

A common financial expression.

Practice 1

> The company is trying to ****balance the books****.

公司正努力令****收支平衡****。

Practice 2

> Higher revenue helped them ****balance the books****.

收入增加幫助他們****平衡賬目****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****balance the books = 令收入和支出在財務上相符或達到可接受平衡****

20. ****balance an account — 核對 / 平衡賬目****

Practice 1

> The accountant ****balanced the accounts**** at the end of the month.

會計師在月底****核對並平衡賬目****。

Practice 2

> I need to ****balance my checkbook/account****.

我需要****核對自己的賬戶收支****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****balance an account = 核對收入和支出，使數字相符****

21. ****balance (天平) — 天平****

A traditional noun sense.

Practice 1

> The scientist placed the sample on a **balance**.

科學家把樣本放在**天平**上。

Practice 2

> The laboratory **balance** is very sensitive.

實驗室的**天平**非常靈敏。

MCQ-ready definition:

balance = 用來精確量度物體質量或重量的儀器

22. **on balance** — 綜合考慮；總的來說

A useful fixed expression.

Practice 1

> **On balance**, I think the plan is a good one.

綜合考慮，我認為這個計劃不錯。

Practice 2

> **On balance**, the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

總的來說，優點多於缺點。

MCQ-ready definition:

on balance = 考慮所有主要正反因素之後作出的整體判斷

23. **tip the balance** — 改變平衡；成為決定性因素

Practice 1

> One vote could **tip the balance**.

一票可能會**改變結果 / 成為決定性因素**。

Practice 2

> The new evidence **tipped the balance in her favour**.

新證據令局勢**轉向對她有利**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****tip the balance = 令原本接近平衡的情況偏向其中一方****

24. **hang in the balance — 懸而未決；結果未定**

Practice 1

> The future of the project **hangs in the balance**.

這個項目的未來仍然**懸而未決**。

Practice 2

> His career **hung in the balance**.

他的職業前途當時**吉凶未定**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****hang in the balance = 結果非常不確定，可能向任何一方發展****

25. **redress / restore the balance — 恢復平衡**

Practice 1

> The policy aims to **restore the balance**.

這項政策旨在**恢復平衡**。

Practice 2

> More support is needed to **redress the balance**.

需要更多支援來**糾正失衡狀況**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****restore/redress the balance = 令失衡的情況重新變得較公平或均衡****

26. ****imbalance — 失衡；不均衡****

Practice 1

> There is a serious ****imbalance**** between supply and demand.

供求之間存在嚴重****失衡****。

Practice 2

> The policy created a regional ****imbalance****.

這項政策造成地區之間的****不均衡****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****imbalance = 不同部分之間的比例、力量或分配不適當****

27. ****unbalanced — 不平衡的；失衡的****

Practice 1

> The load is ****unbalanced****.

負載****不平衡****。

Practice 2

> The report gives an ****unbalanced view**** of the issue.

這份報告對議題的看法****不夠平衡、偏向一方****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****unbalanced = 不同部分比例不當，或明顯偏向其中一方****

Important distinction 1: ****balance vs equality****

equality

means things are equal.

balance

means different things are present in an appropriate proportion.

In your passage:

> firmness + fairness

do not have to be mathematically equal. They simply need to combine well.

So:

balance $\neq$ exact equality

Important distinction 2: **balance vs fairness**

fairness

concerns just treatment.

balance

concerns appropriate proportion between different factors.

Mr Chan's **fairness** is one quality; the **balance** is how fairness combines with firmness.

Important distinction 3: **balance vs compromise**

balance

successfully accommodate different factors.

compromise

each side gives something up to reach agreement.

A balanced solution may involve compromise, but not necessarily.

Important distinction 4: **balance vs moderation**

moderation

avoids extremes.

balance

coordinates different competing factors.

> moderation in spending

適度消費

> balance between spending and saving

消費與儲蓄之間的平衡

Important distinction 5: **balance vs stability**

balance

forces or factors are appropriately distributed.

stability

something remains steady and does not change/collapse easily.

Physical balance can create stability, but they are not identical.

Important distinction 6: **keep your balance vs stay still**

keep your balance

remain physically stable.

stay still

do not move.

A cyclist maintains balance while moving.

So balance does not require stillness.

Important distinction 7: **balance A and B vs choose between A and B**

balance A and B

try to satisfy both.

choose between A and B

select one.

> balance work and family

兼顧工作與家庭

does not mean abandoning one of them.

Important distinction 8: **balanced view vs neutral view**

balanced

properly considers different relevant sides.

neutral

does not favour a side.

A balanced analysis may reach a strong conclusion after considering all sides; it need not remain neutral.

Important distinction 9: **balanced diet vs healthy food**

healthy food

one food judged nutritionally beneficial.

balanced diet

the overall combination and proportion of foods/nutrients is appropriate.

No single food creates a balanced diet by itself.

Important distinction 10: **balance** = account money vs **balance** = physical equilibrium

Completely different learner senses.

> lose your **balance**

失去平衡

> check your bank **balance**

查看銀行餘額

Context is essential.

Important distinction 11: **balance** vs **amount due**

balance

can mean the remaining amount.

amount due

the amount currently required to be paid.

Often overlap in:

> **balance due**

= 尚欠、現需支付的餘額

Important distinction 12: **balance the books** vs **account balance**

balance the books

verb expression:

make financial records add up.

account balance

noun:

amount currently in an account.

They are related financially but distinct.

Important distinction 13: **on balance vs overall**

These are close.

overall

generally, considering everything broadly.

on balance

specifically suggests weighing positive and negative considerations.

> On balance, I support the plan.

綜合利弊後，我認為計劃可取。

So **on balance** carries the metaphor of weighing factors.

Important distinction 14: **tip the balance vs decide**

decide

general.

tip the balance

a relatively small factor causes a close situation to favour one side.

So it emphasizes a **decisive shift in a near-balanced situation**.

Important distinction 15: **hang in the balance vs be uncertain**

be uncertain

general uncertainty.

hang in the balance

stronger and more dramatic:
the outcome is unresolved and important.

Important distinction 16: **imbalance vs difference**

difference

simply not the same.

imbalance

difference severe or inappropriate enough to disturb proper proportion.

> difference in income

收入差異

> income imbalance

收入失衡

Family-extension note

Balance has several major modern branches built around the physical idea of:

weight or force being distributed so that neither side dominates

From that, English develops:

1. **physical equilibrium**

- * keep your balance
- * balance on one foot

2. **proportion between abstract factors**

- * balance between firmness and fairness
- * work-life balance

3. **active management**

- * balance competing priorities
- * balance work and family

4. **healthy/neutral distribution**

- * balanced diet
- * balanced view

5. **financial remainder**

- * account balance
- * remaining balance

6. **financial reconciliation**

- * balance the books

7. **weighing instrument**

- * laboratory balance

8. **figurative weighing expressions**

- * on balance
- * tip the balance
- * hang in the balance

9. **opposite branch**

- * imbalance
- * unbalanced

The passage uses the **abstract proportion** branch: combining two different teacher qualities successfully.

Master comparison

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balance between A and B	A 與 B 之間的平衡	appropriate proportion
find/strike a balance	取得平衡	find middle point
maintain a balance	保持平衡	preserve proportion
physical balance	身體平衡	equilibrium
keep your balance	保持平衡	stay stable
lose your balance	失去平衡	become unstable
sense of balance	平衡感	bodily equilibrium ability
balance something	使某物平衡	stabilize
balance on X	在 X 上保持平衡	physical stability
balance priorities	權衡優先事項	manage competing needs
balance A and B	兼顧 A 和 B	satisfy both
work-life balance	工作與生活平衡	allocation of life
balanced diet	均衡飲食	proper nutritional mix
balanced view	平衡客觀的觀點	considers multiple sides
well-balanced person	性格 / 情緒穩定的人	psychological stability
balance (money)	餘額；結餘	remaining amount
account balance	戶口餘額	money in account
remaining balance	餘款	amount still unpaid
balance due	應付餘額	amount owed
balance the books	使收支平衡	reconcile accounts
balance (instrument)	天平	weighing device
on balance	綜合考慮	after weighing factors
tip the balance	扭轉平衡	decisive shift
hang in the balance	懸而未決	uncertain outcome
restore the balance	恢復平衡	correct imbalance
imbalance	失衡	improper proportion
unbalanced	不平衡的	uneven/biased

For your original sentence

> He was firm, but fair, and that ****balance**** is not easy to find.

Here:

****balance = 兩種不同特質之間恰當而協調的配合****

Mr Chan was:

* firm enough to maintain standards,

* fair enough not to become harsh or biased.

So the sentence is really saying:

he knew how to be firm without becoming unfair

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 他很有原則，但同時也很公道，而這兩者之間的**平衡**其實並不容易掌握。

For this context, **「平衡」** is exactly right, and **「掌握平衡」** is perhaps even more natural than the literal **「找到平衡」** in Chinese.